

ECHOES OF MY FIRST LOVE

Some people leave your life, but never leave your story.

A NOVEL BY YUSUF

CHAPTER ONE

The First Meeting

IF someone had asked me when my story began, I would have given many different answers over the years.

Sometimes I would have said it began in Class Three; the day I stood before my classmates and confessed my feelings to a girl who had unknowingly occupied my heart since childhood. Sometimes I would have said it began with a kiss on my cheek years later.

Sometimes I would have said it began the day I learned that loving someone did not always mean they would love you back.

But none of those answers would have been true. The real beginning was much quieter...

It all began with the nervous footsteps of a little boy walking through the gates of C.V.P.S for the very first time. The corridors were alive with noise.

Children cried as their parents disappeared through the school gate. Others laughed as if they had known one another forever.

Teachers moved from desk to desk, trying to calm frightened pupils while writing names on the attendance register.

I stood quietly near the classroom door, clutching the strap of my little school bag.

Everything looked enormous.

The classrooms.

The playground.

The football field.

Even the giant mango tree outside seemed taller than anything I had ever seen. Nearby stood the “Mabuyu” tree where vendors would later sell snacks during break.

I slowly looked around the classroom, trying to remember every face.

Then I heard it.

A laugh.

It wasn't the loudest laugh in the classroom. It wasn't the kind that made everyone stop and look.

It was warm

The kind of laugh that made you want to know what had made someone so happy.

Without thinking, I turned toward the sound.

My eyes searched through the crowded classroom until they found the little girl who had laughed.

She had round chubby cheeks that made her look cheerful even before she smiled. Her brown hair framed a face that seemed to glow with happiness, and her warm brown eyes sparked with curiosity.

Then she laughed again.

Her smile stretched across her face, revealing a row of perfectly white teeth. Between her two upper front teeth was a tiny gap- not something that took away from her smile, but something that made it unmistakably hers. It was the kind of smile you could recognize from across a playground, the kind that stayed in your memory long after the laughter had faded.

I didn't know her name.

I didn't know where she came from.

I didn't even know if we would ever speak to each other.

But somehow, at that moment, the noisy classroom around me seemed to disappear.

All I could do.... Was keep looking.

The classroom suddenly became quite as our teacher walked in.

She introduced herself as Md Ruth. She wasn't tall, but carried herself with quite confidence. A gentle smile rested on her face as she looked around the room, making even the most frightened children feel a little safer. Her voice was calm and warm, the kind of voice you want to listen.

"Good morning, boys and girls," she said with a warm smile.

A chorus of tiny voices answered her.

"Good morning, teacher."

"I'm very happy to see all of you today. This is the beginning of a new journey. Before we begin learning together, I would like everyone to introduced themselves."

She pointed toward the first desk.

“When I call you, please stand up, tell us your name, and then sit down.”

One by one, the children stood.

Some spoke loudly.

Other whispered so softly that the teacher had to ask them to repeat themselves.

When my turn came, my heart started beating faster.

I slowly pushed my chair back and stood up.

The classroom suddenly felt much bigger than it had few moments earlier.

“My... my..”

The words refused to come out.

As I looked around the room, my eyes wandered towards the front of the classroom.

She was sitting near the window.

The morning sunlight slipped through the open glass, gently lighting one side of her face.

For a brief moment, our eyes met.

Or at least...

It felt that way to me.

My heart pounding so loudly that I was sure everyone else could hear it.

I had spoken in front of people before.

So why couldn't I say something as simple as my own name?

"My... my n-name..."

A few children giggled softly.

Heat rushed to my face.

The teacher smiled patiently.

"Take your time," she said.

I swallowed hard.

"My... my name is Ayaan Omar,"

The words finally escaped my mouth.

I sat down so quickly that I almost forgot to push my chair back under the desk.

My face burned with embarrassment.

I didn't dare look toward the window again.

Not because I was afraid of what I might see.....

But because I was afraid she had noticed just how nervous I had become.

Then the teacher looked toward the girl whose laughter had captured my attention.

She stood up confidently. She smiled before speaking.”
My name is Inaya Hassan.’

I silently repeated the name inside my heart.

Inaya Hassan

Again

And again. As if I were afraid I might forget it. Little did I know, I never would.

Days slowly turned into weeks.

Every morning, I found myself looking toward the same seat near the window.

Every break, my eyes searched for the same smile.

I still hadn’t spoken a single word to her.

Not because I didn’t want to.

Because I didn’t know how.

Until one afternoon.....

My friend Omar, spotted me standing near the football field.

He smiled and waved.

“Ayaan !” he called.

I walked over to greet him.

As I got closer, I noticed he wasn’t alone.

Standing beside her....

Was the girl whose laughter I had carried in my heart since my first day at school.

For a moment, my feet felt as though they had forgotten how to move.

My heart began beating faster.

Omar looked at both of us and smiled.

“Ayaan ,” he said, “this is my friend..”

Before he could finish...

I already knew.

Inaya Hassan

I had repeated that name so many times in my heart that I could never have forgotten it.

Inaya smiled politely.

“HI.”

For a second, my mind became completely blank.

All the words I had imagined saying disappeared.

I managed a small smile.

“H.. hello.”

It wasn’t much of a conversation.

To anyone watching, it lasted less than a minute.

But to me.... It felt the beginning of something new.

As we stood there talking, I realized something.

The girl I had only admired from a distance...

Was no longer just a familiar face in the classroom.

She was becoming my friend.

Every journey has a first step

Mine began with a laugh...

A smile....

And a name I quietly repeated in my heart, afraid I might forget it.

I never did.

Little did I know.....

The next time our path crossed, she would no longer be just another face in the classroom.

She would become my first friend.

And with that friendship....

A story neither of us could have imagined had quietly began.

CHAPTER TWO

Growing Together

People often remember the big moments in life. The first time they fall in love. Their first heartbreak. Their greatest achievement, but childhood has a different way of telling its story.

Sometimes, the moment that shapes us are so small that we don't notice them until years later. A simple greeting. A shared laugh during break time. A conversation that last less than a minute. A friend who slowly become part of your everyday life. Looking back now, I realized that friendship doesn't usually arrive with a grand introduction.

It grows quietly...

One smile, one conversation, one ordinary school day at a time and before you know it, you can't imagine school without that person.

This is how our friendship began.

The days slowly became weeks, and before I realized it, Baby Class had become a memory. The frightened little boy who had once stood at the classroom door, too nervous to say his own name, was slowly beginning to find his place.

Class one felt different.

The classrooms were familiar.

The school that had once seemed enormous had started to feel like a second home.

Some things, however, hadn't changed.

Every morning, before I placed my school bag on my desk, my eyes searched the classroom for one familiar face.

It didn't take long before I found her.

She was sitting with a few classmates, laughing about something I couldn't hear.

That same smile...

The one with the tiny gap between her front teeth..

Appeared once again.

This time, instead of quickly looking away, she noticed me.

For a brief moment, she smiled.

Not because there was anything special between us.

Not because she knew what I felt.

Simply because we had become friends.

I smiled back.

It was a small moment.

So small that anyone watching would probably have forgotten it before the end of the day.

But I remember it.

Sometimes memories refuse to disappear, no matter how ordinary they seem.

As weeks passed, our friendship grew little by little.

There were no grand promises.

No dramatic moments.

Just two children who slowly became comfortable around each other.

Sometimes we only greeted one another before running off to our own friends.

Some days we laughed together.

Other days we hardly spoke at all.

Yet somehow...

Every conversation made us a little less like strangers.

As our friendship slowly grew, talking to Inaya became easier.

Most of our conversation were simple.

Sometimes we talked about homework

Looking back now, that conversation probably wouldn't seem important to anyone else.

To me...

They were enough.

I must confess something

There were days when I already had everything I needed.

My exercise book.

My pencil.

Even my ruler.

Yet somehow, I would still find myself walking over to Inaya's desk.

“Inaya... “

She would look up.

“Yes?”

“My pencil broke. Can I borrow yours?”

She looked at me for a second before opening her pencil case.

She carefully picked out one of her pencils and held it out to me.

But before letting go, she looked straight at me and said, “Return it the way you found it.”

I blinked.

“And don’t break it,” she added.

“If you break it...”

She paused just long enough for me to wonder what she was about to say.

“...you’ll have to buy me another one”.

I nodded so quickly that she laughed.

“I won’t break it.”

Only then did she let go of the pencil.

When I returned it later that day, she examined it carefully.

She rolled it between her fingers.

Checked the tip.

Looked at the eraser.

Only after she was satisfied did she smile and put it back into her pencil case.

At the time, I thought she was being overly protective of her things.

Looking back now...

She treated everything she owned with care.

It was one of the little things I admired about her.

Looking back now, I understand that not every part of life announces itself as important while it is happening.

Some seasons arrive quietly, without drama, without heartbreak, and without the kind of moments people usually turn into stories.

Class one and class two were like that for me.

Nothing extraordinary happened.

There was no grand confession.

No impossible promises.

No heartbreak waiting around the corner.

Just school days passing one after another.

Homework.

Break time conversations.

Shared smiles.

Small excuses to borrow things I didn't really need.

And a friendship that kept growing in the most ordinary way possible.

But sometimes, ordinary is exactly what makes a memory precious.

Those years gave me something I did not yet know how to name.

Not just admiration for a girl with a beautiful smile, but affection for the little things that made her who she was.

The way she guarded her books and pencils as if they were treasures.

The way she noticed when something was out of place.

The way she respected what she had and expected others to do the same.

At the time, I did not think of those details as important.

I was only a boy who liked finding reasons to speak to her.

A boy who pretended to need a ruler when he already had one.

A boy who looked forward to school a little more because he knew she would be there.

Looking back now, I see that Class One and Class Two were not empty years at all.

They were quiet years.

Gentle years.

The kind of years that do not change your life in a single day, but shape your heart slowly, without asking for permission.

By the time those years came to an end, Inaya was no longer just the girl whose laughter had first made me turn my head in Baby Class.

She had become part of my everyday world — familiar, constant, and impossible to ignore.

And without realizing it, I was walking straight toward
Class Three...

toward the day my heart would finally become too full
to stay silent.

CHAPTER THREE

The Day I Found My Courage

Courage wears many faces.

Sometimes it is a firefighter running into a burning
building.

Sometimes it is a soldier standing his ground.

But sometimes...

Courage is nothing more than a little boy standing
in front of his classmates, his knees shaking, his
heart pounding, and his voice barely able to escape
his lips.

Looking back now, I often smile at that little boy.

He didn't understand love.

He didn't understand rejection.

He didn't even understand what the future had
waiting for him.

All he knew was that he had carried a secret in his
heart for years.

And one ordinary school day..

He decided he could no longer keep it there.

That was the day everything changed.

The morning began like every other morning at M.C.P.S.

The first lesson came and went.

Then the second.

Nothing seemed different.

Nothing suggested that by the end of the lunch break, I would do something I had spent years only imagining.

When the lunch bell rang, the classroom quickly emptied.

Some pupils hurried outside to play.

Others gathered in small groups, sharing stories and laughter before the afternoon lessons.

I found myself sitting with the people who knew me best.

My cousin, Omar, who was also one of Inaya's closest friends.

Beside him sat my two best friends, Omar Thwalha and Ali Muhammad.

There was no hiding my feelings from them.

They had watched me steal glances at Inaya since we were little.

They knew exactly who made my heart race.

Omar looked at me with a smile that told me he was about to say something.

"So... Ayaan ," he began.

"When are you finally going to tell Inaya how you feel?"

Ali Muhammad laughed.

"Or are you going to wait until we're all adults?"

Even Omar Thwalha joined in.

"You've liked her for years. Just tell her."

I laughed nervously, trying to pretend it didn't bother me.

"I can't."

"Why not?" Omar asked.

I looked across the classroom.

Inaya was talking to a few classmates, completely unaware that three boys were discussing her only a few metres away.

"I don't know..."

The truth was, I did know.

I was afraid.

Afraid she would laugh.

Afraid she would reject me.

Afraid everyone would know.

The three of them looked at one another before turning back to me.

Almost at the same time, they smiled.

"Today," Omar said.

"You have to do it today."

Omar grinned.

"Ayaan , you've liked her for years."

Ali nudged my shoulder.

"Go tell her."

I shook my head.

"I can't."

Omar Thwalha laughed.

"Can't... or won't?"

"She'll reject me."

Omar looked at me for a moment before smiling.

"You'll never know unless you ask."

Those words echoed in my mind long after he had finished speaking.

I looked down at my hands.

They were trembling.

I didn't know whether it was fear, excitement, or both.

For years, I had carried a secret that only a few people knew.

A secret that had begun with a laugh in Baby Class.

A secret that had followed me through Class One and Class Two.

Now, as we stood in Class Three, it felt heavier than ever.

I slowly lifted my head.

Across the classroom, I saw Inaya.

She was standing with a few of her classmates, laughing about something that I couldn't hear.

She looked happy.

Completely unaware that, only a few metres away, a little boy was trying to gather enough courage to change his own world.

I took a deep breath.

Then another.

"Just walk," I whispered to myself.

"If she says no... at least you'll know."

I looked back at my friends.

None of them said a word.

They simply smiled and nodded.

That was all the encouragement I needed.

I swallowed hard.

Then I took my first step.

Every step toward her felt longer than the last.

The laughter around the classroom slowly faded from my ears.

The voices of the other children disappeared.

All I could hear was the sound of my own heartbeat.

Thump...

Thump...

Thump...

When I finally reached her, I stopped.

She turned toward me.

The smile on her face remained as she looked at me with curiosity.

"Yes, Ayaan ?" she asked.

For a moment...

Every sentence I had rehearsed disappeared.

My mouth felt dry.

I opened it.

Then closed it again.

I almost turned around and walked away.

But then I remembered Omar's words.

"You'll never know unless you ask."

I took one last deep breath.

"Inaya..."

My voice was barely above a whisper.

“I... I like you you”.

Silence.

The classroom suddenly felt much quieter than before.

Inaya’s eyes widened slightly.

She looked genuinely surprised.

She didn’t laugh.

She didn’t smile.

She didn’t say anything at all.

She simply looked at me...

As if she didn’t know what to say.

Those few seconds felt like forever.

I stood there, waiting for an answer that never came.

Eventually, I lowered my head and quietly walked away.

Every step felt heavier than the last.

The classroom that had always felt so familiar suddenly became the last place I wanted to be.

I couldn't bring myself to look at anyone.

Not my friends.

Not my classmates.

And certainly not Inaya.

I sat down in silence, pretending to look at my exercise book, but my mind was somewhere else.

Had I made a mistake?

Should I have kept my feelings to myself?

The questions kept circling in my head, but none of them had an answer.

Lunch came to an end, and the afternoon lessons continued as though nothing had happened.

Yet for me...

Everything had changed.

The following morning began like any other.

The bell rang.

We took our seats.

I expected another ordinary school day.

Instead, our class teacher called my name.

"Ayaan , come to the front."

A strange feeling settled in my stomach.

I slowly stood up and walked to the front of the classroom.

Every pair of eyes followed me.

The classroom was silent.

Our teacher looked at me with disappointment before speaking.

"Do you know why you're here?"

I lowered my head.

She sighed.

"We come to school for one reason."

"To study."

"Not to fall in love."

The words stung more than I expected.

She instructed me to lie down in front of the class.

I obeyed without saying a word.

Then came the punishment.

I slowly stood up.

Every part of me wanted to disappear.

Keeping my head down, I quietly walked back to my desk.

The classroom felt different now.

It was the same room.

The same desks.

The same blackboard.

The same classmates.

Yet somehow...

Nothing felt the same anymore.

I couldn't bring myself to look toward the window.

I couldn't look at my friends.

And I certainly couldn't look at Inaya.

I sat there in complete silence, staring at my exercise book without reading a single word.

Embarrassment has a strange way of making even the smallest classroom feel too big.

At that moment, I made a promise to myself.

I would never speak to Inaya again.

Not because I hated her.

I didn't.

And I don't think she hated me either.

But I couldn't imagine how I was supposed to talk to a girl after she had rejected my feelings.

Everything suddenly felt awkward.

What would I even say?

Would she remember what had happened every time she looked at me?

Would my classmates laugh every time they saw us talking?

Those questions stayed with me for the rest of the day.

As the final bell rang and I walked home, I kept telling myself the same thing.

The next morning, I walked into the classroom just as I always did.

For a brief moment, our eyes almost met.

I quickly looked away.

I wasn't angry.

I was embarrassed.

Days passed.

Whenever I saw her, I kept my distance.

If we happened to be standing near each other, I found a reason to walk somewhere else.

The promise I had made to myself remained unbroken.

As the weeks passed, life at school slowly returned to normal.

Lessons continued.

Homework piled up.

Break time came and went.

My classmates gradually forgot about what had happened.

To them, it had become just another school memory.

But not to me.

I carried that embarrassment with me every single day.

Little did I know...

The story between Inaya and me was far from over.

Looking back now, I often think about that little boy in Class Three. He believed that confessing his feelings would change everything. In many ways...He was right. It changed how he saw himself. It changed how he

looked at the classroom that had once felt so familiar. It changed the way he looked at the girl who had unknowingly occupied his heart since Baby Class. But it also taught him something he was too young to understand. Loving someone does not guarantee they will love you back. And sometimes, the bravest thing you can do is speak the truth, even when the answer isn't the one you hoped for. I carried the embarrassment of that day with me for a long time. I believed I had lost not only the courage to speak to Inaya, but also the friendship we had slowly built over the years. At the time, that felt like the end of my story. Looking back now...I realize it was only the end of one chapter. Because life has a strange way of bringing people back together when you least expect it.

CHAPTER FOUR

The Years Between

Childhood has a strange way of healing broken
things.

We didn't apologize.

We didn't sit down and talk about what had
happened.

We simply grew.

Days became weeks.

Weeks became months.

Somewhere between shared laughter, unfinished
homework, and ordinary school days...

The silence between us quietly disappeared.

Looking back now, I can't remember the exact day
we became close again.

I only remember that one day, without realizing it...

It felt as though we had never stopped being
friends.

Class Four marked the beginning of a new chapter in our primary school lives.

We were no longer the frightened little children who had walked through the school gates for the first time. We knew our classrooms, our teachers, and almost every face around us. The school that had once felt enormous had become a place that felt familiar.

With the new class came a new class teacher.

His name was Mr. Daniel.

He was a skinny, light-skinned man who always carried himself with quiet confidence. He wasn't the kind of teacher who shouted just to prove he was in charge. Instead, he earned our respect through patience and fairness. We all knew he had a habit of smoking at a small shop just outside the school after classes, but inside the classroom he was completely different. He loved teaching, treated every pupil equally, and always wanted us to do our best.

To us, he was simply a good teacher.

As we settled into our new classroom, another unfamiliar face caught everyone's attention.

A new girl had joined our class.

Her name was Nadia Bakari.

She was tall for her age, with dark brown skin and a confidence that made her seem older than the rest of us. Being the new pupil, many of us were curious about her. At first, I thought she would simply become another classmate like everyone else.

I couldn't have been more wrong.

Looking back now, I never imagined that a single person could quietly change the direction of an entire school year.

At first, the signs were so small that I barely noticed them.

She would find reasons to talk to me, even when there was nothing important to say. Sometimes she would start conversations while lessons hadn't begun, and other times during break. I usually answered politely, but I never understood why she seemed so interested in talking to me.

To me, she was just another classmate.

Nothing more.

The first few weeks passed like any other school term.

Lessons became part of our daily routine. Exercise books slowly filled with neat handwriting, homework

became more demanding, and lunch break remained the best part of the day.

Although my friendship with Inaya had begun to recover after everything that had happened in Class Three, it was no longer the same.

We spoke again.

We laughed occasionally.

But there was a quiet distance between us that neither of us seemed willing to acknowledge.

Perhaps we had both changed.

Or perhaps some moments leave behind a silence that takes time to disappear.

Then, one afternoon during lunch break, an ordinary conversation took an unexpected turn.

I can't remember exactly how it started.

A group of classmates had gathered outside the classroom, talking and joking with one another. The conversation drifted from one topic to another until someone suddenly asked,

"Who do you think is the most handsome boy in our class?"

Laughter followed almost immediately.

A few names were mentioned.

Some earned cheers.

Others were met with playful disagreement.

Then Nadia spoke.

"Ayaan."

For a brief moment, everything around me seemed to pause.

I wasn't expecting my name.

To be honest...

I didn't want it to be my name.

Several heads turned toward me.

A few classmates smiled.

Others laughed and started teasing me.

I could feel my face growing warm, but I didn't know what to say.

At first, I thought it would end there.

I told myself everyone would forget about it after a day or two.

Instead...

That was the moment everything quietly began to change.

At first, I tried not to think too much about it.

I convinced myself that she had only mentioned my name because someone had asked a question.

Nothing more.

I simply wasn't interested in the attention she was giving me.

There was someone else who had quietly occupied my heart for years.

Even though Inaya and I weren't as close as we had once been, my feelings for her had never disappeared.

If anything, they had only grown stronger with time.

Before long, it became obvious that Nadia's interest in me wasn't something everyone had imagined.

Some classmates began teasing us whenever we happened to speak.

Others smiled whenever she walked over to my desk.

I laughed it off whenever I could, but inside, I hated every moment of it.

It felt as though I was being pushed into a story I had never wanted to be part of.

The hardest part wasn't the teasing.

It was watching my friendship with Inaya slowly drift further away.

I don't know whether she believed the rumors.

I don't know what she was thinking.

Maybe she simply didn't want to involve herself.

Or maybe...

She had noticed the same things I had.

Whatever the reason, the distance between us grew little by little.

Despite everything that was happening around me, those years were not without moments of laughter.

Some memories still make me smile whenever I look back on them.

One afternoon, during our history lesson, Madam Lydia had been teaching us about some of the African chiefs who ruled different communities during the nineteenth century. Like every other lesson, it eventually came to

an end, and she left the classroom after giving us an assignment.

As soon as she walked out, the classroom came alive again.

Friends began talking across desks.

Some laughed.

Others wandered around before the next teacher arrived.

I was busy chatting with a few classmates and paid little attention to what was happening near the door.

Unknown to me, a few of my friends had taken a small piece of paper and written something on it.

They quietly walked over to the wall beside the classroom door and stuck it there.

None of us noticed.

A few minutes later, the teacher on duty walked in.

The noisy classroom immediately fell silent.

As he looked around the room, his eyes stopped on the small piece of paper attached to the wall.

He walked closer.

Read it.

Then...

He smiled.

Without saying a word, he looked back at the class and asked,

"Who is Chief wa Ng'ombe?"

For a moment, the room was completely silent.

Then every finger in the classroom pointed at me.

Laughter exploded from every corner of the room.

I just sat there, completely confused.

"What?"

The teacher laughed softly, shook his head, and walked out of the classroom.

From that day onward, the nickname refused to disappear.

Very few people called me Ayaan anymore.

To almost everyone in class...

I had become "Chief wa Ng'ombe".

Oddly enough, I never hated it.

It was one of those nicknames that followed me through the rest of primary school, becoming part of my story in a way I never expected.

Life in class soon settled back into its usual rhythm.

The nickname Chief wa Ng'ombe had become part of everyday life. Whenever someone wanted to get my attention, there was a good chance they would call me by that name instead of Ayaan. After a while, I stopped questioning it.

But while everyone else seemed to enjoy the joke, another problem was quietly beginning to grow.

Nadia hadn't stopped trying to get close to me.

If anything, she seemed even more determined than before.

She would often find reasons to start conversations with me, whether they were about schoolwork or something completely unrelated. Sometimes I answered out of courtesy. Other times, I wished the conversation would end before it had even begun.

I never wanted to hurt her feelings.

At the same time, I didn't know how to make it clear that I wasn't interested.

The situation became even more uncomfortable because my feelings had never changed.

Despite everything that had happened in Class Three, Inaya still occupied a place in my heart that no one else could.

I never stopped admiring her.

Unfortunately, feelings are not always invisible.

Before long, Nadia realized where my attention truly was.

I don't know exactly when she figured it out.

Maybe she noticed the way I looked at Inaya.

Maybe someone told her.

Or maybe she simply understood on her own.

Whatever the reason, something changed.

The friendliness she once showed toward Inaya slowly disappeared.

I began to notice a quiet tension between them.

It wasn't loud.

It wasn't dramatic.

But it was there.

And without realizing it, I found myself caught in the middle.

I thought that would be the hardest part of the year.

I was wrong.

The worst was still to come.

The incident itself began with something so ordinary that, at the time, I never imagined I would remember it years later.

It wasn't an argument.

It wasn't a fight.

It wasn't even a misunderstanding.

It was simply...

A pen.

One morning, as lessons were about to begin, I realized I didn't have one.

I searched through my school bag once.

Then again.

I checked my desk.

My pockets.

Nothing.

Without thinking too much about it, I turned around.

"Nadia," I said quietly, "may I borrow your pen? I'll give it back after class."

She looked at me for a moment before handing it over.

"Don't lose it," she said.

"I won't," I replied confidently.

At that moment, I truly believed I meant it.

The lesson came and went.

Then another.

By lunchtime, I reached into my pocket to return the pen.

It wasn't there.

I searched my desk.

My exercise books.

My school bag.

Every pocket I had.

Nothing.

A strange feeling settled in my chest.

I searched again.

And again.

The pen had disappeared.

I never found it.

For the rest of that day, I kept hoping it would somehow appear.

Maybe I had dropped it under my desk.

Maybe I had left it in another classroom.

Maybe one of my classmates had picked it up by mistake.

I searched everywhere I could think of.

But it was gone.

The following morning, before the first lesson had even begun, Nadia walked over to my desk.

"Ayaan," she said. "Where's my pen?"

I looked at her for a moment before lowering my eyes.

"I'm... still looking for it."

She frowned.

"I want my pen."

"I know," I replied. "I'm trying to find it."

She didn't say another word.

She simply turned around and went back to her seat.

At first, I thought she would eventually forget about it.

After all,...

It was only a pen.

I couldn't have been more wrong.

The question followed me every single day.

"Where's my pen?"

At the beginning of a lesson.

"Where's my pen?"

During lunch break.

"Where's my pen?"

As we were going home.

It didn't matter where we were.

She always asked.

Every single day.

I apologized more times than I could remember.

I even offered to buy her another pen.

"I'll replace it," I told her.

"I'll get you a new one."

But she shook her head.

"I don't want another pen."

She looked straight at me.

"I want my pen."

Those words stayed the same every time.

No matter what I said...

Her answer never changed.

Days slowly turned into weeks.

Yet nothing changed.

Every morning, I walked into the classroom hoping she would finally let it go.

Every afternoon, I walked home hoping that somehow, somewhere, I would find the missing pen.

I never did.

It reached a point where hearing my own name made me nervous.

"Ayaan..."

I already knew what was coming.

"My pen."

No matter how many times I apologized...

No matter how many times I offered to replace it...

Her answer never changed.

"I don't want another pen. I want my pen."

At first, some of my classmates laughed whenever she asked.

Later, they stopped laughing.

Even they could see she wasn't giving up.

I started avoiding her whenever I could.

If I saw her walking toward my desk, I would suddenly find a reason to stand up.

If break time came, I would stay with my friends.

Anything...

Just to avoid hearing those same words again.

But no matter what I did...

She always found me.

The classroom, which had once been a place filled with laughter, slowly became a place I no longer enjoyed.

There were moments when I would be laughing with my friends, completely forgetting about everything.

Then Nadia would appear beside me.

"Ayaan..."

The smile on my face would disappear almost instantly.

"My pen."

It was as though every happy moment had an expiration date.

As long as she was around, I knew the question would eventually come.

Little by little...

The weight of that missing pen became heavier than the pen itself.

It wasn't about the pen anymore.

It was about the guilt.

The pressure.

The embarrassment.

And the feeling that no matter what I did...

I couldn't make things right.

Then one day...

Everything became too much.

The weight I had been carrying for weeks finally became too much.

It started like every other school day.

The morning lessons passed quietly.

I tried my best to focus on what the teachers were explaining, but my mind kept drifting elsewhere. Every time I heard footsteps coming toward my desk, I found myself hoping they would continue past me.

Sometimes they did.

Sometimes they didn't.

That afternoon, as we sat waiting for our next lesson to begin, the classroom buzzed with conversation. Some classmates were finishing their homework. Others laughed as they shared stories from lunch break.

For a brief moment...

I forgot about the pen.

I was talking with a few of my friends, laughing at something one of them had said.

Then I heard a familiar voice.

"Ayaan."

The smile on my face disappeared before I even looked up.

Nadia was standing beside my desk.

"My pen."

I closed my eyes for a second before answering.

"Nadia... I'm still looking for it."

She folded her arms.

"You've been saying that for weeks."

"I know."

"So where is it?"

"I don't know."

"You lost my pen."

"I'm sorry."

"I don't want you to be sorry."

She looked straight at me.

"I want my pen."

The classroom had become unusually quiet.
I could feel people listening.
Some looked at us.
Others pretended they weren't.
My heart began to race.
I didn't know what else to say.
I had already apologized.
I had already offered to buy her another one.
There was nothing left for me to give except the one thing I couldn't find.
For a few seconds, neither of us spoke.
Then something inside me broke.
Without saying another word, I stood up.
I pushed my chair back so quickly that it scraped loudly across the classroom floor.
Before anyone could stop me...
I walked out of the classroom.
At first, I tried to hold back the tears.
I told myself I was fine.

I told myself to be strong.

But the moment I stepped outside...

I couldn't hold them back anymore.

Tears rolled down my face as I hurried toward the washrooms, hoping no one would notice me.

At that moment, all I wanted...

Was to disappear.

I don't know how long I had been crying.

It could have been a minute.

It could have been five.

At that moment, time didn't seem to matter.

I wiped my face with the back of my hand, hoping the tears would somehow disappear before anyone noticed.

They didn't.

As I slowly walked toward the washrooms, I heard a voice behind me.

"Ayaan."

I turned around.

It was Mr. Daniel.

He looked at me for a moment before walking closer.

His expression immediately changed.

"What happened?" he asked gently.

I quickly shook my head.

"Nothing, sir."

He looked at my face again.

It was obvious I had been crying.

"You're not fine," he said. "Tell me what happened."

I wanted to.

I really did.

But the words refused to come out.

How was I supposed to explain that I was crying
because of a pen?

It sounded ridiculous.

Even to me.

So, I simply lowered my head.

"I'm okay, sir."

He remained silent for a few seconds, as if waiting for
me to change my mind.

When I didn't say anything, he placed a hand lightly on my shoulder.

"If anything is bothering you," he said, "you can always tell me."

I nodded.

"Yes, sir."

But I never told him.

Not that day.

Not any other day.

After taking a few deep breaths and washing my face, I slowly made my way back toward the classroom.

I wasn't sure what I was expecting.

Another argument.

Another demand.

Another reminder about the pen.

Instead...

Something unexpected happened.

As I entered the classroom, one of Nadia's friends quietly walked over to my desk.

Unlike Nadia, she had always been kind whenever we spoke.

She looked at me for a moment before saying softly,
"Ayaan... if you have another pen, just give it to me."

I looked at her in surprise.

"You mean... she'll accept another one?"

She nodded.

"Yes."

For a second, I couldn't believe what I was hearing.

Without wasting another moment, I reached into my school bag and took out a brand-new pen.

I handed it to her.

She accepted it with a small smile.

"I'll give it to Nadia," she said.

Then, before walking away, she added,

"And don't borrow anything from her again."

I didn't even hesitate.

"I won't."

Not after everything that had happened.

Not after the tears.

Not after the weeks of pressure.

From that day forward, I made myself a quiet promise.

I would never borrow anything from Nadia again.

And whenever I could avoid speaking to her...

I did.

Life slowly returned to normal.

The constant reminders about the missing pen finally came to an end, and for the first time in weeks, I felt as though I could breathe again.

Even though Nadia no longer brought up the pen, something inside me had changed.

I kept my distance from her.

We were still classmates, but that was all.

I no longer borrowed anything from her.

I rarely spoke to her unless it was absolutely necessary.

The memory of those weeks stayed with me, and I had no desire to relive them.

Unfortunately, while all of this was happening, my friendship with Inaya had quietly faded into the background.

We still greeted each other from time to time.

We still shared the same classroom.

But the conversations that had once come so naturally became fewer and fewer.

It wasn't because we hated each other.

It wasn't because we had argued.

Life simply carried us in different directions.

Before I knew it, Class Four had come to an end.

Class Five arrived much more quietly.

There were no unforgettable moments.

No dramatic events.

No stories that changed the course of my life.

It was simply another year of lessons, homework, exams, and the ordinary rhythm of school life.

One piece of news, however, surprised many of us.

Nadia had left the school.

Not only her...

Her close friend had also transferred.

When I heard the news, I felt a sense of relief I couldn't explain.

The chapter of my life that had revolved around one missing pen had finally closed.

Class Six passed in much the same way.

By then, everyone had matured.

We were beginning to understand that primary school wouldn't last forever.

Our focus slowly shifted toward preparing for the years ahead.

Inaya and I still spoke occasionally.

Not often.

But enough to remind me that the friendship we had once shared had never completely disappeared.

Looking back now, Classes Four, Five, and Six were exactly what the title of this chapter suggests...

The Years Between.

They weren't filled with grand adventures or unforgettable achievements.

They were the quiet years.

The years that slowly shaped us without us even realizing it.

And just when I thought the rest of primary school would continue in that same ordinary way...

Class Seven arrived.

With it came new memories.

Epilogue

Not every chapter of our lives is remembered for great victories or unforgettable heartbreak.

Some chapters are remembered for the quiet moments in between.

The years that seem ordinary while we're living them... Yet become meaningful when we look back.

Classes Four, Five, and Six were those years for me.

They taught me that not every challenge arrives in the form we expect.

Sometimes, it comes as a misunderstanding.
Sometimes, as a friendship that slowly fades.
Sometimes... As something as small as a borrowed pen.

Looking back now, I realize those years were never
meant to be the destination.

They were preparing me for what lay ahead.

Because somewhere beyond those ordinary
classrooms... Beyond the laughter... Beyond the
nicknames... And beyond the tears...

Another chapter of my life was quietly waiting to begin.

And when Class Seven finally arrived...

So did someone whose story would forever become part
of mine.

CHAPTER FIVE

The Kiss on My Left Cheek

There comes a point in childhood when you stop
feeling like a little kid, even though the world still
sees you as one.

You begin to understand your emotions a little
better.

Friendships become deeper.

Feelings become more confusing.

And the smallest moments begin to carry the
greatest meaning.

Looking back, Class Seven was the year I truly
began to understand that growing up wasn't
measured by age...

It was measured by the memories that stayed with
us long after they happened.

Class Seven began much like every other school year
before it.

The familiar sound of the morning bell welcomed us back after the holidays. Old classmates reunited with excited conversations, teachers introduced new exercise books, and within a few days, everything felt normal again.

Yet something was different.

We were different.

The playful little pupils we had once been were slowly disappearing. We had grown taller, our conversations had become more mature, and many of us had begun thinking beyond the classroom. We were only one year away from completing primary school, and although we didn't say it aloud, everyone knew that time was moving much faster than it used to.

For me, life continued as it always had.

I still found excuses to talk to Inaya whenever the opportunity presented itself.

Sometimes it was about schoolwork.

Sometimes it was about nothing at all.

The friendship we had rebuilt over the years remained quiet and uncomplicated, but my feelings for her had never disappeared.

I never confessed again after what had happened in Class Three.

There was no need.

I never said the words out loud.

Yet somehow...

Everyone already knew.

My classmates knew.

My friends knew.

And deep down...

I believed Inaya knew too.

No one talked about it anymore.

It had simply become one of those things everyone understood without anyone needing to say it.

As the months passed, Class Seven became another ordinary school year.

Lessons came and went.

Exams arrived and disappeared.

Before we realized it, we were sitting our end-of-term examinations, counting down the days until the December holidays.

The pressure of studying was finally behind us.

For the first time in weeks, everyone could relax.

Some classmates chatted across the room.

Others played simple games to pass the time while teachers finished marking examinations.

The atmosphere was lighter than it had been all term.

It was during one of those ordinary afternoons...

That something happened I have never forgotten

I honestly don't remember how the conversation started.

Sometimes I sit and try to remember the first sentence either of us said, but no matter how hard I think about it, that part of the memory has faded.

All I remember is that we were talking.

A few of our classmates were nearby, laughing and passing the time while we waited for the school day to end. With the examinations behind us, no one seemed too concerned about lessons anymore.

Somehow, our conversation turned into a game.

One question led to another.

One joke followed the next.

Then, without thinking too much about it, I looked at Inaya and asked,

"Can I kiss you?"

The words escaped my mouth before I had time to think about them.

For a brief moment, everything became quiet.

I waited for her to laugh.

Or tell me I was being ridiculous.

Or even remind me of what had happened back in Class Three.

Instead...

She looked straight at me with a calm expression.

"You can," she said.

I blinked, unsure if I had heard her correctly.

"You can kiss me anywhere you want on my body."

She wasn't laughing.

She wasn't smiling.

She looked completely serious.

My heart immediately began beating faster than it ever had before.

I could feel the heat rushing to my face.

My palms became sweaty.

Every word I had planned to say disappeared from my mind.

I didn't know whether she was joking.

I didn't know whether she was testing me.

All I knew was that the answer I had expected...

Wasn't the answer she had given me.

The only thing I managed was a nervous smile.

And then...

I did absolutely nothing.

I didn't kiss her.

I couldn't.

Even today, I still ask myself the same question.

What would have happened if I had?

Would she have pulled away?

Would she have laughed?

Would our friendship have changed?

I honestly don't know.

That moment has remained one of the greatest "what ifs" of my life.

At the time, I thought that was the end of it.

I thought it would simply become another memory that would quietly fade away with time.

I had no idea...

Life was quietly preparing something even more unforgettable.

The school eventually closed for the December holidays.

Like every year, most of us left the school gates excited for the weeks ahead. No more lessons. No more homework. No more examinations.

Or so we thought.

Before leaving, the teachers informed us that during the holidays, each class would return on a specific day to help clean the school. It had become part of our school's tradition. Every class was assigned its own day to sweep classrooms, clean the compound, and prepare the school for the next academic year.

When the day for Class Seven finally arrived, I woke up early and made my way to school.

As expected, not everyone came.

There were always those who ignored the instructions and chose to stay home.

But many of us still showed up.

When we arrived, our names were written down before we were divided into different groups and given our tasks.

For the next few hours, the school that had once echoed with lessons and laughter became filled with the sounds of brooms scraping against classroom floors and students talking as they worked.

By midday, we had finished.

Everyone was tired, but there was a different kind of happiness in the air.

The holidays had officially begun.

As we stood around outside the classroom, preparing to leave, Inaya slowly walked toward me.

I remember looking at her, wondering what she wanted.

Then she smiled.

"Ayaan," she said, "can you make me one of those beaded bracelets... the ones with names on them?"

At the time, they had become incredibly popular.

Almost everyone wanted one.

Fortunately, I knew how to make them.

For a brief moment, I looked at her without answering.

Then an idea crossed my mind.

An idea I never thought I would actually say out loud.

I smiled.

"I'll make it for you..."

I paused just long enough to make her curious.

"...but on one condition."

She looked at me with a puzzled expression.

"What condition?"

I looked straight into her eyes.

"You have to kiss me."

For a second...

She froze.

A faint blush slowly appeared across her face.

It was the first time I had ever seen Inaya blush because of something I had said.

My heart was beating just as fast as it had that day in the classroom.

But unlike before...

She wasn't angry.

She wasn't offended.

She simply lowered her eyes for a moment...

Then looked back at me.

"...Okay."

For a moment, neither of us said anything.

I wasn't expecting her to agree so easily.

If anything, I had expected her to laugh, call me crazy, or simply walk away.

Instead...

She had said yes.

I could still see the blush on her face as she looked down, avoiding my eyes.

I don't know whether her friends had overheard our conversation or whether she told them afterwards.

To be honest...

I never asked.

What I do remember is that none of them seemed surprised.

Perhaps they had always known how I felt about Inaya.

Just like everyone else in our class.

We gathered our things and began walking toward the school gate with the rest of our classmates.

Some were talking about the holidays.

Others were already making plans for the weeks ahead.

I walked quietly beside Inaya, my heart refusing to slow down.

As we stepped outside the school gate, I looked at her and smiled.

"So..."

I said softly.

"What about our deal?"

She immediately looked around.

Her face turned red once again.

"I can't..."

she whispered.

"Not here."

I understood exactly what she meant.

Our friends were only a few steps ahead of us.

Anyone could turn around at any moment.

Without saying much, I called out to them.

"You guys go on ahead."

"We'll catch up."

They looked back at us for a moment before continuing down the road.

Soon, the distance between us and the others became a little wider.

Even then...

Inaya still looked too shy to move.

I smiled to myself.

Then I picked up one of my exercise books and held it between us, shielding her from anyone who might look back.

"It's okay," I said gently.

"You don't have to kiss me on the lips."

I pointed to my left cheek.

"Just here."

She looked at me for a second.

Then, very slowly...

She stepped closer.

Time seemed to stand still.

Without saying a single word, she leaned toward me.

I could feel my heart pounding against my chest.

Then...

Her lips gently touched my left cheek.

It wasn't rushed.

It wasn't forced.

It lasted only a brief moment.

But in that moment...

It felt like the whole world had gone silent.

I could even feel the slight moisture on her lips against my skin before she slowly pulled away.

Neither of us spoke.

We simply looked at each other for a moment.

Then I smiled.

"I'll make your bracelet," I said.

She smiled back.

"Thank you."

Together, we walked toward our friends as though nothing had happened.

A few minutes later, our paths separated.

She headed home with her friends.

I headed home with mine.

We waved goodbye.

None of us knew it then...

But I had just experienced a moment that would stay with me for the rest of my life.

I walked home that afternoon feeling as though I was floating.

The world around me hadn't changed.

The sun still shone as brightly as it always had.

People continued with their daily lives.

But to me...

Everything felt different.

My friends noticed it immediately.

"What happened?" one of them asked with a grin.

I couldn't hide it any longer.

I smiled.

"Inaya kissed me."

The moment those words left my mouth, they burst into laughter.

Some refused to believe me.

Others kept asking how it had happened.

I told them everything—from the bracelet to the kiss outside the school gate.

By the time I finished, they were laughing so hard that some of them could barely speak.

Then I made a declaration that only a boy in Class Seven could make.

"I'm not going to touch my left cheek."

They stared at me.

"What?"

"I'm serious," I said. "I'm not touching it."

That only made them laugh even harder.

I knew it sounded ridiculous.

Even I couldn't explain why I felt that way.

I simply didn't want anything to erase the memory of that kiss.

As lunchtime approached, we stopped at a small hotel to eat before everyone headed home.

The entire time we were eating, I was careful.

I avoided touching the left side of my face.

Every now and then, one of my friends would laugh and jokingly pretend he was about to touch it.

I would quickly move away, making everyone laugh all over again.

To them, it was just another funny moment.

To me...

It meant everything.

Eventually, we finished our lunch and went our separate ways.

I kept my promise all the way home.

Not once did I touch my left cheek.

I smiled to myself.

Maybe...

Just maybe...

I could keep that promise forever.

I had no idea that before the day came to an end...

I would break it without even realizing it.

The afternoon slowly faded into evening.

One by one, everyone had returned to their homes, and the excitement of the day quietly began to settle.

I was still smiling.

Every time I remembered what had happened outside the school gate, I couldn't help but touch my lips before quickly stopping myself.

"No," I whispered with a smile.

"Not the left cheek."

I had made myself a promise.

As childish as it may sound now, I was determined to keep it.

I wanted that kiss to remain exactly where it had been placed.

Untouched.

As the afternoon drew to a close, it was time for Asr prayer.

I picked up my towel and walked to perform my wudu.

Without thinking, I turned on the tap and began washing my hands.

Then my mouth.

Then my nose.

Everything was normal.

Then I cupped water into my hands and splashed it across my face.

Once.

Twice.

Three times.

It wasn't until I had finished washing my face that a sudden thought struck me.

I froze.

"My cheek..."

I stared at my wet hands for a moment before slowly touching the left side of my face.

I had forgotten.

Without even realizing it...

I had washed away the very cheek I had promised never to touch.

For a second, I couldn't help but laugh at myself.

There was nothing I could do now.

The promise had been broken.

Not because I wanted to break it...

But because life had simply continued.

I finished my wudu and walked to the mosque for Asr prayer.

As I stood in prayer, my cheek no longer carried the warmth of Inaya's kiss.

But my heart still carried the memory.

And somehow...

I knew it always would.

Epilogue

“Looking back now, I realize that the kiss itself wasn't what stayed with me.

It was the feeling.

The innocence.

The hope.

The memory.

Some memories fade with time.

Others grow quieter...

Yet they never truly leave us.

They wait patiently, hidden in the corners of our hearts,
until one day they return and remind us of who we once
were.

And when I look back on that December afternoon, on
that shy smile, on that kiss upon my left cheek...

I don't just remember a moment.

I remember the beginning of the echoes of my first
love."

CHAPTER SIX

The Final Year

Before the Story Began

There are some people who enter your life and leave
without making much of a difference.

Then there are those who arrive quietly, almost
unnoticed, and somehow become part of a chapter
you will remember for the rest of your life.

This is a story about one of those people.

It is not a story about a perfect love.

It is not a story about two people who met, fell in
love, and lived happily ever after.

In fact, it is almost the opposite.

It is a story about growing up.

About friendship.

About the strange innocence of childhood.

About the first time your heart chooses someone
before you even understand what love really means.

And most importantly, it is a story about a girl
named Inaya.

But before she became Inaya in the pages of this

story, she was simply the girl I met at M.C.P.S.
Back then, I didn't know that a simple conversation
with another child could become a memory that
would follow me for years.

I didn't know that the girl sitting somewhere in my
classroom would eventually become the first person
to teach me what it felt like to care deeply about
someone.

I didn't know that there would be laughter,
friendship, jealousy, rejection, unexpected
friendships, heartbreak, and moments I would wish
I could experience again.

I was just a child.

She was just a girl.

And school was just school.

At least, that's what I thought.

Looking back now, I realize that childhood has a
strange way of hiding important moments inside
ordinary days.

A classroom can become the beginning of a lifelong
memory.

A simple conversation can become something you
remember years later.

A smile can stay in your mind longer than you ever
expected.

And sometimes, the person you love most isn't
necessarily the person you end up with.

That is one of the hardest lessons I learned.

For years, I carried feelings I didn't fully
understand. I watched friendships change, watched

people come and go, and slowly discovered that
growing up meant accepting things I couldn't
control.

There were moments when I thought I had finally
moved on.

There were moments when I was certain I hadn't.
And there were moments when I wondered whether
everything had happened for a reason.

Maybe it had.

Maybe some people aren't placed in our lives so
that we can keep them forever.

Maybe they are there to shape us.

To teach us.

To give us memories that become part of who we
are.

This is the story of my first love.

Not because it was perfect.

Not because it lasted forever.

But because it was the first time my heart learned
what it meant to love someone before my mind was
old enough to understand it.

So, before you turn the page, forget everything you
know about love.

Forget the stories where everything works out
perfectly.

Forget the endings you expect.

Because this story began long before I understood
what it was becoming.

It began beneath a mango tree.

At M.C.P.S.

With two children who had no idea that their first meeting would become a story worth remembering.

And this...
is where it all began.

The final year began with us entering the last class of M.C.P.S.

By then, we were no longer the same children who had once run beneath the mango tree without a care in the world. We had grown. We had gained knowledge, experienced things, made mistakes, and slowly begun to understand that life would not remain within the walls of our school forever. Soon, each of us would have to choose a direction and decide what we wanted to make of our lives.

As always, the first day of school came with mixed feelings. Some students arrived unwillingly, already wishing the holidays had lasted a little longer, while others came excited to see their friends again.

We spent the first day cleaning and preparing our new classroom, settling into what was supposed to be our final chapter at M.C.P.S.

But for me, there was something else about that day.

It was the first time I saw Inaya again after the kiss on the cheek.

I wondered whether she had already forgotten about it. Maybe to her, it had been nothing more than a small moment from the previous year—something that had happened and disappeared with time.

But for me?

That moment lived rent-free in my mind.

I remembered it more often than I cared to admit.

After that first day, life slowly returned to normal. We went back to our lessons, our books, our jokes, and the new syllabus that waited for us.

But there was one major change.

The teacher who had been our class teacher from Class Four all the way to Class Seven was suddenly no longer our class teacher.

We were all surprised.

Somehow, we had always imagined that he would be the one standing before us when we finally completed primary school. We had grown accustomed to him being there. But life has a way of changing plans without asking for permission.

None of us knew what was waiting ahead.

Only the Almighty knew.

Our new class teacher was a woman. She was kind, carried herself confidently, and was introduced to us as Madam Khadija.

After getting to know her, she made her first major decision as our teacher: she was changing the seating arrangement.

Her reasoning was simple.

If we sat next to our closest friends, we would spend the entire lesson cracking jokes, laughing, and doing everything except concentrating on our studies.

And honestly, I couldn't blame her.

She was right.

So she took us outside the classroom and instructed us to form two separate lines—one for the boys and another for the girls.

Then she began choosing our new seating arrangements.

One boy.

One girl.

One desk.

I stood there quietly, but somewhere inside me, I was praying for something I didn't even dare to say aloud.

Let me sit with Inaya.

Then it happened.

Madam Khadija called my name.

And then she called hers.

Inaya.

For a moment, I couldn't believe it.

We were going to sit at the same desk.

Inside, I was jumping with joy.

Outside, all I could manage was a faint smile.

My friends noticed immediately.

One of them whispered,

“Go, Ayaan.”

I tried to act normal.

“Okay.”

But inside, I was celebrating.

When I finally sat beside Inaya, I suddenly didn't know what to say.

It was strange.

There were so many things I could have said to her. So many conversations I had imagined having. But whenever I looked at her, whatever words had been in my mind disappeared.

So, most days, we didn't talk much.

When I needed something, I would ask her.

When she needed something, she would ask me.

That was our friendship.

Simple.

Quiet.

But inside me, things were anything but simple.

I was deeply in love with her.

And somewhere in my heart, I already knew something I didn't want to accept.

Inaya saw me as a friend.

She had boundaries, and she never crossed them.
Maybe she had never looked at me the way I looked at
her. Maybe she never would.

I knew that.

Yet knowing something doesn't always make it easier to
feel.

Sometimes, I would see her talking to another boy,
laughing at something he had said, and I would feel a
small sting of jealousy.

I had no right to feel that way.

She was my friend.

She had done nothing wrong.

Still, my heart didn't understand what my mind already
knew.

One afternoon, while we were sitting at the same desk,
the classroom was unusually quiet. Most of the
students were busy with their work.

I looked at Inaya for a moment.

There was something I had wanted to ask her for a long
time.

“Inaya?”

She turned toward me.

"Yes?"

"Can I ask you something?"

She looked at me suspiciously.

"What?"

I hesitated.

"Do you have someone you love?"

She stared at me for a second before smiling.

"Why are you asking me that?"

"I don't know. I'm just asking."

She laughed.

"That's a strange question."

"Just answer."

She thought for a moment.

"No."

I raised my eyebrows.

"No one?"

"No one."

I smiled slightly.

"Then what kind of person would you want as a boyfriend?"

She laughed again.

"Why do you want to know my qualifications?"

"I'm just curious."

"Curious about what?"

I looked away.

"Nothing."

She shook her head, still smiling.

"You're asking too many questions."

"I'm only trying to understand."

"Understand what?"

I didn't answer.

She looked at me for a moment, then turned back to her book.

"You're funny, Ayaan."

I smiled to myself.

The conversation hadn't given me the answer I was secretly hoping for, but at least I had asked.

And sometimes, when you are young and in love, even a small conversation can stay in your mind for much longer than it should.

But those days of sitting beside her would soon be shattered.

We were told that Madam Khadija was no longer going to be our class teacher.

The classroom immediately became noisy.

"Finally!" one of the boys shouted.

Another laughed.

"Now we can go back to our original seats!"

Everyone seemed excited about returning to the people they had been sitting with before.

Everyone except me.

I smiled along with everyone else, pretending that I was just as happy.

But inside, I felt completely different.

I knew what returning to our original seats meant.

Inaya would go back to her desk.

And I would go back to mine.

The short time we had spent sitting together was about to become another memory.

We would still be in the same classroom, studying the same subjects and preparing for the same examination, but somehow I knew things would not be exactly the same anymore.

Our new class teacher was introduced to us as Mr. Bickson.

He came into the classroom, greeted us, and stood at the front while everyone settled down.

“Good morning, everyone.”

“Good morning, sir!” we answered.

“My name is Mr. Bickson, and from today, I will be your class teacher.”

Someone at the back whispered,

“So you're the one replacing Madam Khadija?”

A few students laughed.

Mr. Bickson smiled.

“Yes. And I hope you will not make me regret accepting this class.”

The classroom became even louder.

He raised his hand.

“Don't worry. I'm not here to make your lives difficult. But I expect you to work hard, especially because this is your final year.”

The noise slowly died down.

“You are preparing for KCPE. Every week matters. Every examination matters. So from today, I want us to take our studies seriously.”

Then, to our relief, he didn't tell us to change our seats.

Everyone settled down happily.

It was also around this time that a new boy joined our class.

His name was Muhammad said.

He was tall—not extremely tall, but taller than most of us—and dark, though not extremely dark.

Within less than a week, he had already become familiar with almost everyone.

He was the kind of person who could enter a new environment and become part of it almost immediately.

Days went by.

We were now doing examinations almost every week as we prepared for KCPE.

But during that period, I started noticing something.

Muhammad was around Inaya most of the time.

Even though they were not sitting together, I would see them together during break.

At lunchtime.

And even when we were going home in the evening.

At first, I tried to convince myself that it meant nothing.

They were probably just friends.

But the more I saw them together, the harder it became to ignore.

Then one day, one of my friends came to me.

“Ayaan.”

“Yeah?”

“I heard something.”

“What?”

“There are rumors going around in class.”

I frowned.

“About what?”

He lowered his voice.

“About Muhammad and Inaya.”

My heart immediately sank.

“What about them?”

“People are saying Muhammad is in love with Inaya.”

I didn't respond.

He looked at me.

“Ayaan?”

“Yeah?”

“You okay?”

I forced a smile.

“I'm fine.”

Another friend came over.

“What happened?”

He answered before I could.

“He just told Ayaan about Muhammad and Inaya.”

My friend looked at me sympathetically.

“Ah, man...”

I looked away.

For once, I didn't have anything to say.

I had spent so long hoping that maybe one day Inaya would see me differently.

But now there was someone else who seemed to be getting closer to her without even trying.

And every time I saw them laughing together, it hurt.

Still, there was someone who could sometimes make me forget about all of that.

Aliyah.

After our unexpected meeting some time earlier, our friendship had slowly grown.

We began talking more often.

Sometimes, during break, I would make my way to her classroom just to see her.

We would sit and talk about school, friends, and completely ordinary things until the bell rang.

"Break is over already?" I would ask.

Aliyah would laugh.

"You were the one who came here."

"I didn't know time was moving so fast."

"You just don't want to go back to your class."

"Maybe."

She would smile.

Sometimes she brought me small gifts, and sometimes I brought something for her too.

Our classmates had started noticing.

One day, one of my friends sat beside me and looked at me seriously.

"Ayaan, I need to tell you something."

"What?"

"You should forget about Inaya."

I looked at him.

"What are you talking about?"

"You know exactly what I'm talking about."

I remained quiet.

He continued.

"Look at what is happening. You keep waiting for Inaya to love you back, but you already know she probably doesn't feel the same way."

I frowned.

"Probably?"

"Okay, maybe I shouldn't say probably. But look at what you're going through."

He pointed toward where Inaya was standing with some of our classmates.

"You've been carrying these feelings for a long time."

I sighed.

"So what do you want me to do?"

"Aliyah."

I looked at him.

"What about her?"

"Have you ever noticed how she looks at you?"

I didn't answer.

He continued.

"She likes you, Ayaan."

"How do you know?"

"Because everyone can see it except you."

Another friend joined the conversation.

"He's actually right."

I looked at him.

"You too?"

"Yes. Think about it. Aliyah always makes time for you. She gives you gifts. You go to her class just to talk to her. You two already get along."

My first friend nodded.

"And most importantly, she doesn't make you spend every day wondering whether she cares about you."

I looked down at my desk.

He continued more gently.

"I'm not telling you to forget Inaya overnight. I'm telling you to stop hurting yourself waiting for someone who may never feel the same way."

I stayed quiet.

"Give Aliyah a chance," he said. "At least find out how she feels."

For a long time, I thought about those words.

Every day, I would see Inaya and Muhammad together.

Every laugh.

Every conversation.

Every moment they spent around each other seemed to make my decision a little easier.

Eventually, I decided that I would bury what I felt for Inaya.

Not because my feelings had suddenly disappeared.

They hadn't.

But because sometimes you have to accept that loving someone doesn't mean they have to love you back.

Aliyah's birthday was approaching.

At that point, I still wasn't completely certain that she liked me.

She had never actually told me.

But my friends were convinced.

And maybe they were right.

So when her birthday finally arrived, I decided to do something I had never done before.

I wanted to tell her how I felt.

Her birthday happened to fall on a school day, so I bought a cake.

It wasn't a huge cake.

Just something simple.

I carried it to school along with a present.

During the long break, my friends helped me prepare everything.

We wrapped the present carefully and prepared the cake.

Then they helped me write the letter.

I knew what I wanted to say, but putting those feelings into words was harder than I expected.

Eventually, the letter was ready.

My friends looked at me.

"You ready?"

I took a breath.

"I think so."

One of them smiled.

"Then let's go."

We walked toward Aliyah's classroom.

When we entered, everyone joined in singing for her.

She looked surprised.

Then she saw the cake.

Her face immediately lit up.

"Is this for me?"

I smiled.

"Happy birthday."

She looked genuinely happy.

"Thank you!"

She looked at the cake, then at the presents.

"You guys actually did all this?"

One of my friends laughed.

"Of course."

She thanked everyone, and for a while the classroom was filled with laughter and excitement.

Eventually, people began leaving.

One by one, my friends stepped outside.

Soon, it was just Aliyah and me.

I held the letter in my hands.

"Aliyah."

She looked at me.

"Yeah?"

"I have something for you."

She looked at the letter.

"What is it?"

"Just read it."

She took it from me.

I stood there quietly while she opened it.

The Letter

Dear Aliyah,

I don't really know how to begin this because I have never been very good at saying these things out loud.

We've known each other for some time now, and somewhere along the way, you became someone I genuinely enjoy having around.

I like talking to you.

I like the way you make time for me.

I like the little things you do that make ordinary days feel different.

For a long time, I thought my heart belonged somewhere else, and maybe part of it still does. But I have realized that sometimes we spend so much time looking at someone who isn't looking back that we fail to notice the person who has been standing beside us all along.

I don't know exactly what you feel about me, and that's why I'm writing this instead of simply saying it.

But I want you to know that I like you.

I care about you.

And if you feel the same way, I would like to give us a chance to see where this friendship can go.

You don't have to answer immediately.

I just wanted you to know the truth.

Happy birthday, Aliyah.

— Ayaan

She finished reading.

For a moment, she said nothing.

Then she smiled.

She looked at me.

“Yes.”

I wasn't expecting such a simple answer.

“Yes?”

She nodded.

“Yes.”

“You mean...?”

She laughed softly.

“I like you too.”

I couldn't hide my smile.

She continued.

“I actually liked you from the first time we saw each other.”

I stared at her.

“You did?”

She nodded.

“I was just too shy to tell you.”

At that moment, everything I had been worrying about suddenly felt distant.

Aliyah had liked me all along.

And somehow, I had been too busy looking in another direction to notice.

Then the bell rang.

Class was about to begin.

Outside the classroom, my friends were waiting.

The moment I walked out, they immediately surrounded me.

“Well?”

I smiled.

One of them grabbed my shoulder.

“Why are you smiling like that?”

I couldn't stop smiling.

"What happened?" another asked.

I looked at them.

"She said yes."

There was a brief silence.

Then everyone started shouting.

"I told you!"

"You see!"

"Finally!"

One of them laughed.

"So you finally listened to us?"

I shook my head, laughing.

"Yeah. Maybe you were right."

Another friend looked at me.

"And what did she say?"

"She said she liked me too."

They all celebrated.

"Let's go!"

"We're going to be late!"

We started running back toward our classroom, laughing like children who had just won something important.

And perhaps, in that moment, I felt like I had.

For the first time in a long time, my heart wasn't waiting for Inaya to choose me.

It had found somewhere else to rest.

Days went by, and for a while, everything seemed fine.

Only my closest friends knew about my relationship with Aliyah. We had decided to keep it between ourselves, but secrets rarely stay secret for long at school.

People began noticing.

Even Inaya noticed.

Sometimes she would make jokes whenever she saw me with Aliyah.

"So, you two are always together these days?"

I laughed awkwardly.

"What's wrong with that?"

"Nothing," she said, smiling. "I'm just asking."

Another time, she teased me about it in front of some of our classmates.

“You've forgotten your old friends now.”

I laughed.

“I haven't forgotten anyone.”

She shook her head.

“Hmm. I don't believe you.”

I smiled, but inside, I couldn't help wondering whether she really meant anything by those jokes or whether she was simply teasing me as a friend.

My relationship with Aliyah continued to be good.

But there was one thing I couldn't completely control.

Sometimes, without even realizing it, I would look across the classroom for Inaya.

Just a quick glance.

Just to see what she was doing.

And almost every time I looked, I saw her with Muhammad .

Talking.

Laughing.

Walking together.

Each time, I felt that same old pain.

I kept telling myself that it would eventually disappear.

I was with Aliyah now.

I had made my choice.

Surely my feelings for Inaya would fade with time.

At least, that's what I told myself.

Then came the birthday party.

One of our classmates organized a birthday celebration at her home and invited almost everyone from our class.

Of course, everyone wanted to go.

The house was beautifully decorated, music was playing, and food seemed to be everywhere.

For a while, I actually enjoyed myself.

We wished her a happy birthday, ate, talked, laughed, and eventually people started dancing.

I wasn't really interested in joining the crowd, so I stepped away and watched everyone from a distance.

I looked around the room.

And then I saw them.

Muhammad walked toward Inaya.

He said something to her.

She smiled.

Then he held out his hand.

“Dance with me.”

Inaya looked at him for a moment.

Then she agreed.

They walked onto the dance floor.

I stood there watching.

At first, I tried to convince myself that it didn't matter.

Why should it?

I wasn't with Inaya.

I was with Aliyah.

I had no reason to feel jealous.

But emotions don't always listen to reason.

The longer I watched them, the worse I felt.

They moved together with the music, laughing and completely absorbed in the moment.

I looked away.

Then, somehow, my eyes returned to them.

I couldn't stop watching.

My chest felt tight.

I began wondering why something so simple was hurting me this much.

I already had a girlfriend.

I had chosen Aliyah.

So why did seeing Inaya with someone else feel like something was being taken away from me?

Then Muhammad leaned toward Inaya and kissed her on the cheek.

The students around them immediately reacted.

“Hey!”

“Look at them!”

“Inaya and Muhammad !”

People laughed and teased them.

Inaya didn't seem bothered by the attention.

But I couldn't stay there.

I turned around and walked out.

Then I walked faster.

I didn't say goodbye to anyone.

I didn't explain myself.

I simply left.

By the time I reached home, everything I had been holding inside for so long finally broke through.

I went into my room and sat down.

For a few moments, I just stared at the floor.

Then the tears came.

I tried to stop them.

I couldn't.

All the feelings I had buried for months seemed to come rushing back at once.

The memories.

The conversations.

The times I had sat beside Inaya.

The times I had watched her laugh with other boys.

The hope that perhaps one day she might see me differently.

And now, the image from the party.

I had spent so much time telling myself that I was over her.

But that night proved that I wasn't.

Not even close.

I cried until I was exhausted.

Eventually, I wiped my face and sat quietly.

I was angry.

Not at Inaya.

Not even at Muhammad .

I was angry at myself.

Why had I allowed myself to remain trapped in feelings I knew I couldn't control?

Why had I convinced Aliyah that I could give her something I wasn't ready to give?

I sat there for a long time before making a promise to myself.

Whatever happened next, I never wanted to let my feelings take control of me like that again.

That night, I decided it would be the first and last time a girl would make me cry.

The next morning, I went to school as if nothing had happened.

My friends immediately noticed something was missing.

One of them came up to me.

"Ayaan, where did you disappear to yesterday?"

I shrugged.

"I had to go home."

"During the party?"

"Yeah."

"Why?"

"Something came up."

He looked at me suspiciously.

"What kind of something?"

"Nothing serious. I just needed to leave."

Another friend joined us.

"You missed everything after you left."

I forced a smile.

"Yeah, I know."

They looked at each other, clearly unconvinced, but eventually let it go.

When break time came, I made my way toward Aliyah's classroom.

I asked her to come somewhere quiet because I needed to talk to her privately.

She followed me.

"What happened?" she asked.

I took a breath.

"Aliyah, I think we should stop seeing each other."

She stared at me.

"What?"

"I think we should break up."

Her expression changed immediately.

"Why?"

I couldn't tell her the real reason.

I couldn't tell her about Inaya.

So I gave her the only answer I could manage.

"I just think it's better if we stop."

"But why?" she asked again. "Did I do something?"

"No."

"Then what happened?"

"Nothing happened."

She looked confused.

"Ayaan, you were fine with me yesterday. You were fine with me this morning. How can you suddenly tell me you don't want us anymore?"

I looked away.

"I just don't think this is working."

Her voice became quieter.

"Do you still like me?"

I hesitated.

That hesitation told her more than my words could.

She looked down.

"I don't understand."

"I think we should just stop seeing each other."

She stood there silently.

"Is that really what you want?"

I nodded.

"I'm sorry."

She didn't answer.

I turned around and walked back toward my classroom.

With every step, I hated myself a little more.

I knew exactly what I had done.

I had hurt someone who had done nothing wrong.

Aliyah had liked me.

She had trusted me.

She had given me her time, her attention, and her feelings.

And I had walked away without telling her the real reason.

I felt like a jerk.

But I kept convincing myself that I had done the right thing.

What would have been worse?

Continuing a relationship with someone who genuinely cared about me while knowing that my heart was still somewhere else?

I didn't think that would be fair to her.

As I walked toward my classroom, I argued with myself.

"You should have been honest."

"But what would I have told her?"

"The truth."

"And what would that have changed?"

"Maybe she deserved to know."

"You already hurt her."

I stopped for a moment.

That last thought was the one I couldn't escape.

I had hurt her.

And there was no way around it.

Still, I convinced myself that ending things was better than pretending.

She deserved someone whose heart was completely with her.

Mine wasn't.

Even after I returned to class, I didn't tell any of my friends what had happened.

But they started noticing that something wasn't right.

Aliyah sent her friends almost every day to my classroom.

One of them would come over.

"Ayaan, Aliyah wants to talk to you."

"I'm busy."

"She has been waiting for you."

"I'll talk to her later."

"When?"

"I don't know. Just tell her I'm busy."

Another day, another one of her friends came.

"Ayaan, seriously. Go talk to her."

"I can't."

"Why?"

"I'm just busy."

"You've been saying that for days."

"I know."

"So what are you hiding?"

"Nothing."

She looked at me.

"Then why won't you talk to her?"

I had no answer.

She eventually walked away.

My friends began noticing that something was wrong.

One afternoon, they finally confronted me.

"Ayaan, what's going on?"

"Nothing."

"Don't say nothing."

"I'm fine."

"No, you're not."

I looked at them.

"What makes you think that?"

"You've been acting differently since the party."

Another friend added,

"And Aliyah's friends keep coming here asking for you."

I remained silent.

"Did something happen between you two?"

I sighed.

"Yes."

They immediately became serious.

"What happened?"

I looked down.

"I ended it."

They stared at me.

"You broke up with Aliyah?"

"Yes."

"Why?"

I didn't want to answer.

"Ayaan, why?"

I finally said the words I had been using to convince myself.

"I don't love her anymore."

My friend frowned.

"That's it?"

"That's it."

"But she really liked you."

"I know."

"And you just ended everything?"

"I thought it was better."

"Better for who?"

I didn't answer.

Another friend shook his head.

"Man, you should have at least told her the truth."

I looked away.

Maybe he was right.

But I wasn't ready to tell them the truth either.

So I repeated the only explanation I had given myself.

“I don't love Aliyah anymore. It was better for both of us.”

They were still confused.

They didn't know about the party.

They didn't know what I had seen.

They didn't know that beneath everything I had said, there was one truth I was still desperately trying to hide.

I had never really stopped loving Inaya.

As the examination drew closer, however, I decided to focus completely on my studies.

Everyone was preparing.

Books were everywhere.

Teachers were giving us revision papers almost every day.

Every conversation seemed to involve examinations and what would happen after primary school.

I buried myself in my work.

I rarely even took a glimpse at Inaya anymore.

One day, one of my friends came to me during break.

“Ayaan.”

“Yeah?”

“I heard something.”

I continued looking through my book.

“What?”

“You know Muhammad ?”

I looked up briefly.

“Yeah.”

“He apparently confessed to Inaya.”

I paused.

“And?”

My friend looked surprised.

“She rejected him.”

I nodded.

“Oh.”

“That's all you're going to say?”

“What else should I say?”

He laughed.

"Didn't you used to care about this stuff?"

I returned my eyes to my book.

"People change."

"So you don't care?"

"No."

He looked at me for a few seconds.

"Well... apparently she told him she only wanted them to remain friends."

I nodded.

"Okay."

He laughed.

"You're seriously not bothered?"

I smiled slightly.

"I'm studying. Let me finish this."

He shook his head.

"You're different now."

Maybe I was.

For the first time, I wasn't interested in knowing who Inaya liked.

I had something else to focus on.

My future.

And strangely enough, my marks began proving that I was making the right decision.

My scores started improving.

Then they improved again.

Soon, I was scoring marks I had never imagined getting before.

One day, our class teacher stood in front of everyone holding our examination papers.

“Ayaan.”

I looked up.

“Yes, sir?”

“You've improved tremendously.”

The whole class turned toward me.

He smiled.

“Your marks are now much higher than what you used to get. Keep this up.”

I smiled.

“Thank you, sir.”

The class applauded.

I sat down feeling proud.

For once, I wasn't thinking about Inaya.

I was thinking about myself.

About what I could accomplish if I actually put my mind to something.

Only a few months remained before KCPE when our class teacher rearranged the seating arrangement again.

That was when I properly met someone I had been sitting in the same classroom with all along without really noticing her.

Her name was Monica.

I eventually gave her a nickname.

Monic.

She was a good girl and, from what I quickly learned, a very religious one.

We were placed on the right side of the classroom.

Across from us sat one of my closest friends, Fahmi.

Fahmi had his own love story.

And honestly, his story was much sweeter than mine.

Mine seemed to be built from confusion, rejection, jealousy, and heartbreak.

His seemed much simpler.

But then again, perhaps I was just unlucky in love.

Monic and I became close surprisingly quickly.

At first, we were simply friends.

Then we started talking more.

And more.

We joked with each other, shared things, helped each other with schoolwork, and sometimes spent more time talking than we probably should have.

There were moments when someone would look at us and ask,

“Are you two together?”

We would immediately answer,

“No.”

But sometimes even we knew that our friendship didn't look like an ordinary friendship.

We acted like a couple without actually being a couple.

We teased each other.

We looked for each other during breaks.

We shared little things.

If one of us was absent, the other would notice.

And sometimes we would sit together quietly without needing to say anything at all.

It was almost like being in a relationship without giving it a name.

But I knew my limits.

After everything that had happened with Inaya and Aliyah, I didn't want to throw myself into another relationship.

Monic also knew my story.

She knew about Inaya.

She knew about Aliyah.

She knew about the heartbreak, the confusion, and everything that had happened between them.

So she understood something that perhaps other people didn't.

There was no real chance of us becoming a couple.

And honestly, I was okay with that.

One of the things I admired most about her was her faith.

Every Wednesday evening, she would attend Catholic studies while the rest of us continued with our evening lessons.

Sometimes I would tease her about it.

"You're leaving us again?"

She would smile.

"Yes."

"Every Wednesday."

"Of course."

"You really don't miss it?"

"No."

I would laugh.

"You're serious."

She would simply smile.

That was Monic.

She knew what she believed in, and she stayed true to it.

Our friendship remained one of the simpler things in my final year.

No promises.

No expectations.

Just two people who became close during a time when life was changing quickly.

Then, almost without warning, the final examination arrived.

The examination that would determine our KCPE index numbers.

The exam that everyone had been talking about for months.

We sat for it.

And then it was over.

For years, we had complained about school.

We had complained about teachers.

We had complained about homework.

We had counted down to the day we would finally leave.

But when that day actually arrived, none of us seemed completely ready.

We celebrated.

We laughed.

We said goodbye.

But beneath all the excitement was one uncomfortable thought.

Would we ever see each other again?

We had spent years together.

Some of us had known each other since we were children.

And now, suddenly, everyone was going their own way.

The days after the examination felt strangely empty.

Then came the waiting for the results.

And that waiting was perhaps harder than the examination itself.

Every time I heard someone mention the results, my heart would jump.

“Are they out?”

“No.”

Another day.

“Have you heard anything?”

“Not yet.”

I tried to act calm.

But inside, I was constantly thinking about it.

What if I didn't do well?

What if all those hours of studying hadn't been enough?

What would my marks look like?

What would everyone else get?

Every passing day seemed longer than the one before.

Then, finally, the results came.

My heart was beating hard as I waited to see my marks.

I took a breath.

Looked.

And there they were.

I had done quite well.

Above average.

I felt relieved.

Proud.

After all the studying, the stress, the examinations, and everything else that had happened during that final year, I had made it.

But then I learned something else.

Out of all 420 students from our school who had sat for the examination, only two of us had tied on the final marks.

Me.

And Inaya.

I stared at the result for a moment.

Then I laughed quietly to myself.

Of all the people.

After everything that had happened between us.

After eleven years.

After the two times I had been rejected.

After the jealousy.

After watching her with Muhammad .

After trying to move on.

After convincing myself that I had finally left those feelings behind.

We had somehow ended up with exactly the same final marks.

It almost felt like the universe was playing a cruel joke on me.

I couldn't help thinking about what it would have been like if things had turned out differently.

What if Inaya had loved me the way I loved her?

What if we had actually been together?

What if, after eleven years of knowing each other, we had sat somewhere together and discovered that we had tied in a national examination?

Maybe we would have laughed about it.

Maybe we would have celebrated together.

Maybe that would have been the perfect ending to our story.

But life doesn't always give you the ending you imagine.

Sometimes two people can spend eleven years walking through the same story and still end up taking completely different paths.

And perhaps that was what the universe had planned for us all along.

We had entered M.C.P.S as children.

We left carrying different dreams, different hopes, and different futures.

None of us knew where life would take us.

But one thing was certain.

Those years had changed us.

And no matter where we went afterward, there would always be a part of us that belonged to those classrooms, those friendships, those ordinary school days, and the people who made them memorable.

The school chapter was over.

The final bell had rung.

But the memories?

Those were only beginning to live on.

EPILOGUE

WHAT REMAINED

"Years have a strange way of changing everything.

The places we once knew become different.

The people we once saw every day slowly become strangers.

The classrooms that once felt like our entire world become memories.

And somehow, the children we once were disappear without us even noticing.

Sometimes I think about M.C.P.S.

I think about the classrooms.

The desks.

The teachers.

The laughter.

The arguments.

The examinations.

The mango tree.

And most of all, I think about the people who made those years what they were.

Some remained in my life.

Others became nothing more than names attached to memories.

And then there was Inaya.

For a long time, I thought my story with her was supposed to have a different ending.

I imagined what it would have been like if she had chosen me.

If the feelings I carried for so many years had been returned.

If the story had gone the way I wanted it to.

But growing up taught me something I couldn't understand back then.

Not every story is written to give us what we want.

Some stories are written to teach us.

Inaya was my first love.

She was the first person who made me understand why a simple smile could stay in someone's mind.

She was the first person who made me feel jealousy, hope, disappointment, and happiness all at once.

And she was also the first person who taught me that loving someone doesn't mean you get to have them.

That lesson wasn't easy.

There were moments when I wished I could go back and change things.

Moments when I wished I had said something differently.

Moments when I wished I had been brave enough.

And moments when I wished I had simply let go sooner.

But I don't regret knowing her.

I don't regret the friendship.

I don't regret the memories.

Because without those experiences, I wouldn't be the same person I became afterward.

Maybe that is what first love is really about.

It isn't always about finding the person you will spend your life with.

Sometimes it is about meeting someone who leaves a permanent mark on a younger version of you.

Someone who becomes part of the story you tell when
you remember who you used to be.

When I look back at those years now, I don't see a boy
who lost the girl he loved.

I see a boy who was learning.

Learning what love was.

Learning what rejection felt like.

Learning how to let go.

Learning that other people have their own choices,
their own feelings, and their own paths.

And perhaps most importantly, learning that life
continues even when something you once thought was
everything comes to an end.

Our final day at M.C.P.S wasn't the end of our lives.

It was simply the end of the world we knew at that
time.

We walked away from those classrooms carrying
different dreams.

Different hopes.

Different futures.

None of us knew where life would take us.

Maybe that's what made those final days so emotional.

We knew we were leaving something behind.

But we didn't yet understand that we were also leaving behind versions of ourselves that would never return.

The little boy who first met Inaya beneath the mango tree was gone.

The boy who waited for her attention was gone.

The boy who thought first love had to become forever was gone too.

What remained was the memory.

A memory of a girl.

A school.

A friendship.

A first love.

And a chapter of life that could never be repeated.

Sometimes, when I remember those days, I smile.

Not because everything worked out the way I wanted.

But because, for a little while, life was simple.

We were children.

We had classrooms instead of careers, examinations instead of responsibilities, and dreams that seemed impossibly far away.

We didn't know how quickly those days would disappear.

Maybe that's why memories become so precious.

We only realize how beautiful a moment was after it has already become the past.

And if I could go back, I wouldn't change the story.

Not the happiness.

Not the mistakes.

Not the heartbreak.

Not even the ending.

Because every part of it became part of me.

Somewhere in the past, beneath a mango tree at M.C.P.S, a boy met the first girl he would ever love.

He didn't know what that meeting would become.

He didn't know how many memories would follow.

He didn't know that one day he would sit down and write the story of it all.

He only knew her name.

And maybe that was enough.

Because some people leave your life...

but never really leave your story.

The End

EPILOGUE

What Remained

EPILOGUE

“Years have a strange way of changing everything.

The places we once knew become different.

The people we once saw every day slowly become strangers.

The classrooms that once felt like our entire world become memories.

And somehow, the children we once were disappear without us even noticing.

Sometimes I think about M.C.P.S.

I think about the classrooms.

The desks.

The teachers.

The laughter.

The arguments.

The examinations.

The mango tree.

And most of all, I think about the people who made those years what they were.

Some remained in my life.

Others became nothing more than names attached to memories.

And then there was Inaya.

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